board, would need a ‘sweetener’, and so would the *Guardian* for that matter. He ‘understood’ that neither paper found the material to be that compelling and they wanted a little sugar on their porridge: namely, they wanted the entire cache of Iraq documents, too. I should have withdrawn at that point, seeing what was obvious: that these people were not gentlemen and did not know how to value significant data and human complexity for what it was. I should have spotted the self-serving glint in the news reporter’s eyes and walked away. The world was full of media organisations who would have moved mountains to join us in the work we had been doing. But these papers, even at the earliest stage, were on a fault-finding mission, looking to exploit us as best they could. This *Guardian* reporter was stimulated, you could see, not by principle, but by the chance to please his bosses and score one last scoop before he retired.

But we marched on. I liked the *Guardian* and wanted to believe it would come good. It knew what these leaks represented and I saw no real problem with the ‘sweetener’, other than the manner of its being asked for. In any event, I supplied them and the *New York Times* with the Iraq logs. It was all to the good, I kept saying, we’re not in this for gratitude. If they put their resources behind both sets of logs, then the basic cause of openness and freedom of information will have been served. My only real job now was to work with them to get the best out of the material. Well, not my only job: I also had to keep them honest, which quickly proved to be a full-time occupation. It’s really an unsavoury tale and I wish I didn’t have to tell it, but they have at length, and in gross personal terms, so we must go on. What I can tell you is that I was under the greatest pressure of my life. I was being surveilled; I was living out of a rucksack; when I was sleeping at all, I was sleeping on sofas; people beyond my reach were being arrested; and I was fighting to keep the whole vast dreadnought on an even keel. I was tired. I wasn’t always accommodating. I wasn’t always conventional. Not always nice. But I thought these were men of action and principle, not weaklings with a crush, and it was difficult to see the way they moved around me so gingerly and sometimes full of hurt, like I wasn’t giving them enough attention or showing my best side.

My best side was in the work. I had brought them into a partnership that was about to give them the best scoops of those successive wars. And people had risked their lives, we had to suppose, in order to get that news to the world. In London I spent weeks at the *Guardian*’s offices in King’s